
Guide to Creating a Data Governance Program

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Introduction

The purpose of this guide is to provide organizations of varying size, domain and data literacy guiding principles for developing a local Data Governance (DG) plan. This guide outlines common key components of a DG program and provides leading questions so individual organizations using this guide can determine if a given key component should be included and/or steer modification in the use of their unique program.

This guide is not intended to be used as a specific DG program plan, but rather to act as a tool to help organizations build an effective DG program. This process will flow through four distinct phases:

Engagement | *The WHY*

These exercises are intended to clarify the purpose and scope of the DG plan.

Strategy | *The WHAT*

These exercises will help integrate DG into the fabric of the organization's mission, values, and goals.

Architecture & Design | *The HOW*

This section will help you build a DG program that works within the specific structure of your organization.

Implementation | *Putting DG Into Practice*

This section will help you navigate the process and potential challenges of putting the DG program into practice.

Throughout the guide, we have provided specific action items to help you create your DG program step-by-step. While you may find that some of these steps are not needed for your organization, you should at least consider each step and be thoughtful about whether they need modification to be relevant to your organization. This individualization is a normal part

of building a data governance program!

Look for the action steps in the following format:

Action Item

Description

To assist in visualizing how your organization may individualize a data governance plan using this guide, we have also provided examples from three different types of organizations throughout this guide. We hope these will help ground the guiding principles and key concepts in applicable scenarios as you work.

Here are descriptions of the three sample organizations. Look for these examples in the following format:

Paravolt

Technology | 30 Employees

A sustainable energy start-up developing “smart sensors” for monitoring and optimizing energy service delivery.

Nelson Family Funeral Home

Small Business | 7 Employees

Small, family-run funeral home offering embalming services, funeral hosting and emotional support.

Twin Lakes Regional Hospitals

Healthcare Organization | 150 Employees

Hospital system serving multiple rural communities, comprised of one level III trauma hospital, one dialysis center and one urgent care center.

01 Engagement

Making the Case for DG

Initiate

At this phase, it is important to understand you are building a DG *program*, not a project. Eventually, your goal is for DG to disappear into the operation of the organization, not for it to become a separate function or department.

Action Item: Obtain support of leadership

You want to ensure leadership understands the value of and is invested in creating a long-term and sustainable approach to DG.

It is also important to formally recognize the team will work to get the DG program off the ground, whether that team consists of one person or five. This rollout team is not permanent but may bring in different roles as your data governance work takes shape. These should be individuals with a thorough understanding of the business as well as some experience in how the organization uses data, with the skills to recognize data issues. They should also have the internal political capital to push for organizational change. It is important that DG is not considered an IT project, but rather an essential business function.

The DG team should represent diverse roles and perspectives from across the organization. This means including senior leadership who can champion the initiative as well as mid-level and junior employees who understand the day-to-day challenges. You want a mix of specialties: for example, you may want someone from operations who knows business processes, someone with technical expertise who knows the data systems, and someone from a customer-facing role who can speak to stakeholder needs. This diversity ensures that your DG program addresses real problems from multiple angles and gains buy-in across different organizational functions.

Avoid building a team composed entirely of IT staff or senior executives. While both groups are important, a team that lacks operational diversity may not be able to identify practical data issues and may inadvertently design a governance plan that looks good on paper but fails in practice. If your organization is small and you cannot assemble a diverse team, consider having your designated DG lead conduct listening sessions with employees from various roles to gather their perspectives before moving forward with program design.

Action Item: Establish the team

Make sure leadership is aware of who will be working on setting up the DG program, and ensure that these employees are recognized for and supported in their efforts.

When assessing individuals who may have capacity to grow into these roles, consider that data can reach across employees from many different backgrounds.

Define

Next, you should frame DG within the context of the organization. How will DG affect your business specifically? Draft a clear, brief definition of DG and what data is to be managed. This will be key in justifying the program to employees who may not yet agree with you on the value of DG.

Action Item: Define DG for your organization

Create a simple, concise, and sincere definition of DG for your organization and tie it back to what DG will do for the organization.

Here are some examples of a DG definition for our three sample organizations:

Paravolt

Technology | 30 Employees

DG is the orchestration of people, processes, and technology to effectively leverage data as an asset.

Nelson Family Funeral Home

Small Business | 7 Employees

DG is the set of principles and processes that define: (1) who can access sensitive client data and (2) under what circumstances.

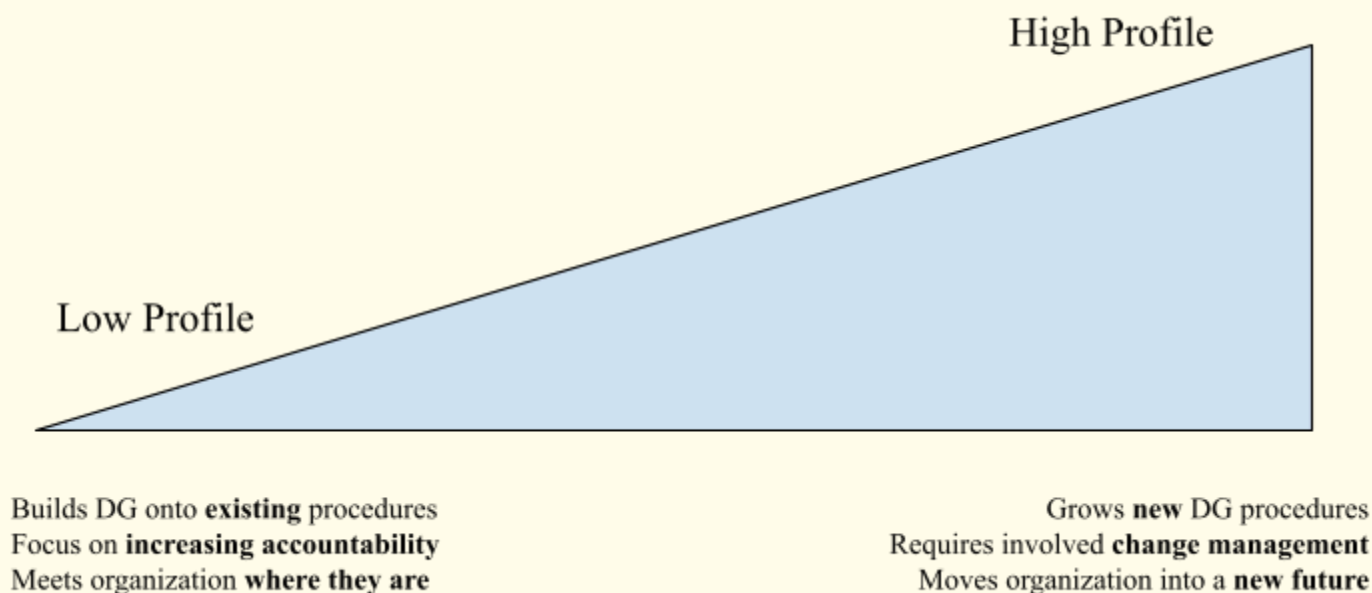
Twin Lakes Regional Hospitals

Healthcare Organization | 150 Employees

DG is the exercise of executive authority over the organization's data to ensure data is accurate, unbiased, and timely. DG enforces the consistent, integrated, and disciplined use of data in service of our mission to provide the best possible care to our patients.

Scope

Once DG has been defined for your organization, you must then determine the scope of the program. Which employees or departments will be affected? Who are the stakeholders?



While building the components of your DG program, it might be helpful to think about where you may want to fall on the spectrum from low-profile to high-profile programs.

A typical low-profile approach addresses an area that is already working with data and helps that area adopt a more formal approach to data oversight. Conversely, a high-profile approach builds new data systems and awareness where it did not exist before.

Action Item: Identify the scope & get agreement

Identify at least one or two areas that will be impacted by the DG program. A great way to define the scope is to define which data capabilities you aim to improve. Ensure that leadership agrees with the scope and will provide the DG team with the authority they need to implement the desired changes.

Assess

Next, you will want to explore the current use of data within the organization. Where is data being used? How is it being used? By whom? What are the pain points? Your intent is not only to confirm the current state of data in the organization, but also to discover potential obstacles to a sustainable DG program.

You want to ensure that the organization is prepared to view data as an asset that should be managed, secured, and accounted for, just as you would with financial assets or physical assets (such as buildings or inventory). This mindset is the foundation of DG. If there is pushback against this philosophy in certain departments or with certain employees, you may need to take extra time to understand and alleviate their concerns. If you don't, then your DG efforts are likely to fail.

Some of your questions may include:

- What are the key indicators that measure performance in your department / role?
- Do you use data analysis to make changes in your work process and improve results?
- What are the current rules for sharing and moving data in and out of the organization?
- What databases, spreadsheets, or other data stores do you currently use?
- Do you collect information related to your work?
- How do you currently ensure data quality?

It might be helpful to think about classifying items you come across using a table that includes columns such as:

- Data name
- Data source
- Examples of key measurements
- Does the data contain linkages to other data sources?
- Can the data's usability be improved?
- Do we need to continue to collect this data?
- Does this data contain private or sensitive information?

Data may be sitting in vast and surprising places within your organization. Remember to not assume certain corners or units of the business do not collect data. It may also be helpful, as you survey, to keep track of data possibilities that arise as you interact with various staff and stakeholders. If you want your DG program to be sustainable it has to grow with the data opportunities of your organization.

The old, or maybe new, adage is that data is an asset to your organization. Like other assets to benefit you most, this asset must be managed and protected to be available for leveraging when you need it. Often advice about how to manage this asset is in the context of a profit driven organization. But the data asset can also be leveraged to achieve other goals within your organization, such as:

- To improve efficiency
- To protect consumers
- To drive research and development

If your assessment reveals reluctance or even hostility toward the DG initiative, then you should begin to address these concerns now. Consider the following tips:

- Listen to pushback to find the genuine concerns and separate them from the frustration with change that may be packaged with them.
- Lead education efforts that meet people where they are in terms of understanding and keep in mind they may understand the concept you are explaining but use different terminology.
- Bring employees into the strategic goals the DG efforts align with, especially strategic goals that they may care about as individuals.

Action Item: Assess the current state of data

Do some initial exploration of how data is currently used and viewed within your organization.

If you need help identifying data in your organization, check the examples in the Data Identification Checklist in the Templates section.

Action Item: Address concerns & pushback

As you move through your assessment, be on the lookout for any concerns or pushback about the DG program. Make a plan to address these concerns and follow through to establish trust.

02 Strategy

Laying the Foundation for DG

Vision & Plan

Once an initial assessment has been completed, it is important to understand what the organization defines as success. The Strategy phase is where you connect data governance to your organization's actual goals and daily operations. By the end of this phase, you should be able to clearly answer: "Why are we doing this?" and "What will success look like?" This section will help you build a DG program that supports your organization's current goals while ensuring your data practices are ethical and equitable.

The most successful DG programs are those that directly support the goals your organization is already prioritizing. Consider where your organization is headed. What are the key goals over the next few years? Where might challenges arise? If your organization has strategic planning documents, look to these to guide your research. Brainstorm ways that DG can help meet these goals, and identify a few areas to focus your initial DG efforts. Consider goals that involve:

- Improving efficiency or reducing costs
- Growing revenue
- Enhancing customer/client experience
- Ensuring compliance with regulations
- Launching new products or services

Action Item: Identify your organization's priorities

Review strategic planning documents, recent board presentations, or leadership communications from the past year. If these do not exist, schedule conversations with your organization's key leaders and ask: "What are the top three things you are trying to accomplish this year?"

Action Item: Choose one to three goals to focus on

You can't improve everything at once. Select one to three goals where:

- Leadership cares deeply about the outcome
- You have identified clear data opportunities
- You have a realistic chance of making progress in 6-12 months

Action Item: Map data opportunities to goals

For each priority goal, ask yourself: "Where could better data help achieve this?" Create a simple table that connects organizational goals to specific data opportunities.

Nelson Family Funeral Home

Small Business | 7 Employees

<u>Goal</u>	<u>How Data Could Help</u>	<u>Specific Data Needed</u>
Improve effectiveness of website and increase visits by 15%	Track which pages visitors view most, how long they stay, and what actions they take	Website analytics (page views, time on site, click patterns, referral sources)
Maintain accurate inventory	Improve inventory process through more efficient collaboration between weekday and weekend staff	Elimination of missed order deadlines and out of stock notices
Provide compassionate service after the loss of a loved one	Understand which services families value most and identify opportunities to improve experience	Service feedback surveys, follow-up communication

Twin Lakes Regional Hospitals

Healthcare Organization / 150 Employees

<u>Goal</u>	<u>How Data Could Help</u>	<u>Specific Data Needed</u>
Reduce patient wait times in urgent care by 20%	Identify bottlenecks in patient flow and optimize staffing schedules	Patient arrival times, triage duration, examination room utilization, discharge times, staffing levels by hour
Improve coordination between facilities	Ensure patient records and care plans are accessible across all three locations	Unified patient records system, medication lists, treatment histories, specialist referrals
Launch diabetes prevention program	Identify at-risk patients and track program effectiveness	Patient A1C levels, BMI, family history, program participation rates, health outcome changes

Existing Capabilities & Tools

There is a temptation to dive directly into the weeds in order to show immediate value by designing a plan, appointing stewards, and launching new initiatives. The biggest mistakes are made when an organization rushes to buy new tools or consultants to “handle” DG for them. This can quickly become expensive and often results in frustrating DG efforts that are doomed to fail because they are not integrated with the company mission and culture.

Now that you know where you want DG to help, you need to understand what capabilities you already have and what gaps exist. This will prevent you from making the mistakes described above.

Action Item: Inventory your existing data capabilities

Create a list of current capabilities in your organization. Consider dividing these into three categories: technical capabilities, people capabilities, and process capabilities.

Action Item: Identify capability gaps

Based on your goal-mapping exercise and capability inventory, identify two to four specific gaps that would prevent you from achieving your DG goals.

Twin Lakes Regional Hospitals

Healthcare Organization / 150 Employees

<u>Capability Area</u>	<u>What We Have</u>	<u>What's Working</u>	<u>What's Missing</u>
Data Storage	Customer database (Salesforce), financial data (QuickBooks), sensor data (AWS S3)	Salesforce is well-organized and accessible	Sensor data is siloed; engineers can't easily access customer usage patterns
Data Analysis	Three engineers are comfortable with Python/SQL, sales team uses Salesforce reports	Engineering team produces good technical analysis	No one connects technical data to business outcomes; no cross-functional analysis

Principles

Principles are the philosophical foundation of your DG program. They are the core beliefs that will guide decisions when your organization faces challenges. Principles anchor the formation of policies and set the tone and foundation for the entire DG program.

Principles can be organization-wide or specific to the governance of your organization's data. These principles may be an assertion to guide your organizations' decision making to be more morally sturdy, scientifically rigorous, or true to your brand.

We suggest that you start with the list of Generally Accepted Information Principles (GAIP™) created by John Ladley. Identify two to four principles that resonate for your organization and build these into your DG plan.

Generally Accepted Information Principles

by John Ladley¹

1. Data as an Asset

Data of all types are assets with all the characteristics of any other asset. Therefore, they should be managed, secured, and accounted for as other material or financial assets.

2. Real Value

There is value in all data, based on their contribution to an organization's business / operational objectives, their intrinsic marketability, and / or their contribution to the organization's goodwill (balance sheet) valuation.

3. Going Concern

Data are not viewed as a temporary means to achieve results (or merely as a business by-product), but are critical to successful, ongoing business operations and management.

4. Risk

There is risk associated with data. This risk must be formally recognized, either as a liability or through incurring costs to manage and reduce the inherent risk.

5. Due Diligence

If a risk is known, it must be reported. If a risk is possible, it must be confirmed.

6. Quality

The relevance, meaning, accuracy, and life cycle of data can affect the financial status of an organization.

7. Audit

The accuracy of data is subject to periodic audit by an independent body.

8. Accountability

An organization must identify parties that are accountable for data assets.

9. Liability

The risks in information mean there is a financial liability inherent in all data that is based on regulatory and ethical misuse or mismanagement.

¹ Ladley, John. *Data Governance: How to Design, Deploy, and Sustain an Effective Data Governance Program, Second Edition*. Academic Press, 2020.

Action Item: Establish your DG principles

Select two to four principles from the list above that:

- Address challenges you identified in your assessment
- Support the goals you're trying to achieve
- Reflect your organization's values and culture

You want to avoid having too many principles, using the description to declare how the principle will be enforced, or mentioning specific areas or functions within the principle.

Paravolt

Technology | 30 Employees

Principle: Data as an Asset

Our Statement: Customer usage data from our sensors is as valuable as the sensors themselves. We will manage this data strategically, investing in its quality and accessibility, because it drives our competitive advantage.

Description We are a startup competing against larger companies. Our sensor data gives us unique insights into energy usage patterns, but currently this data sits in technical systems that only engineers can access. If we treat data as an asset, we can use it to improve our products, better serve customers, and demonstrate ROI to potential clients.

What This Means in Practice:

- We will invest in tools that make sensor data accessible to non-technical team members (product, sales, customer success)
- When making build-vs-buy decisions, we'll consider the long-term value of the data we collect, not just immediate functionality

- We'll track data assets in our business planning, just as we track physical inventory and intellectual property
- We'll assign clear ownership for different data sets, with accountability for their maintenance and quality

Ethical Considerations: When we treat customer usage data as a valuable asset, we must also recognize our responsibility as stewards of that asset. Customers trust us with sensitive information about their energy consumption patterns, which could reveal when they're home, their daily routines, and their financial circumstances. We will not monetize customer data through sales to third parties, and we will be transparent about how we use data to improve our products. Our commitment to data as an asset includes the ethical obligation to protect that asset from misuse.

Potential Challenges: As a small startup, we have limited budget and engineering time. We'll need to be strategic about which data investments provide the most business value first, rather than trying to perfect everything at once.

Integrate Data Ethics into Your DG Strategy

Data governance is not just about managing data effectively — it is about managing data *responsibly*. Ethical considerations should be woven throughout your DG program, not treated as an afterthought. This section will help you identify potential ethical concerns and build safeguards into your strategy from the beginning.

Data ethics involves asking critical questions about how data practices affect people—both inside and outside your organization. Key ethical considerations include:

- **Privacy & Consent:** Do people know what data you're collecting and how you're using it? Have they had a meaningful opportunity to consent?

- **Fairness & Equity:** Could your data practices advantage some groups while disadvantaging others?
- **Transparency & Accountability:** Can you explain your data decisions? Is someone responsible when things go wrong?
- **Dignity & Respect:** Do your data practices treat customers as people, or merely as means to organizational goals?
- **Beneficence & Non-maleficence:** Are you actively trying to benefit stakeholders? Are you working to prevent harm?

Action Item: Conduct an ethical assessment of your data practices

Select two to four principles from the list above that:

- Address challenges you identified in your assessment
- Support the goals you're trying to achieve
- Reflect your organization's values and culture

For each principle, document three to five specific commitments about how you will handle data ethically.

Twin Lakes Regional Hospitals

Healthcare Organization / 150 Employees

Focus Area: Launch diabetes prevention program (identifying at-risk patients)

Stakeholders Affected:

- Patients (especially those with pre-diabetes markers)
- Staff who will use data to identify and contact patients
- Underserved communities who may already face healthcare access barriers

Privacy Considerations:

- *What data:* A1C levels, BMI, family history, demographic information
- *Awareness:* Patients know we're collecting health data, but may not know we're using it to identify them for prevention programs
- *Consent:* We should add a clear notice during intake explaining that we may contact them about relevant programs
- *Retention:* Health data must be retained per HIPAA requirements, but program participation data could have shorter retention

Fairness Considerations:

1. *Risk:* Our historical data shows lower screening rates in our most rural communities. If we only use existing data to identify at-risk patients, we'll miss people who haven't been regularly screened—perpetuating existing health disparities
2. *Action needed:* We should combine data-driven identification with proactive outreach to underscreened communities
3. *Who benefits:* Prevention program will benefit patients identified early, but relies on patients' ability to attend appointments and afford recommended lifestyle changes
4. *Mitigation:* Offer telehealth options and subsidized program fees based on income

Transparency Considerations: We can clearly explain we're using routine health data to identify patients who might benefit from prevention. If asked, we should be able to show patients what data we used to identify them and why they qualified.

Dignity Considerations: While we are identifying patients who might benefit, they choose whether to participate. We are not making assumptions about their lifestyle or commitment.

Harm Prevention: A data breach could reveal health conditions patients want to keep private; could lead to stigma or discrimination. We should put safeguards in place so that all data access is logged and audited.

Ethical Commitments: Based on this assessment, we commit to:

1. Transparent communication with patients about how their data identifies them for prevention programs
2. Regular equity audits to ensure we're not systematically missing underserved populations
3. Making participation genuinely optional with no negative consequences for declining
4. Minimizing data collection to only what's necessary for program effectiveness

03 Architecture & Design

Building the Structure of the DG Program

In this section, you will formalize the DG program, and you will build out your DG capability into something that can be implemented.

It is important at this stage to remember that DG is not data management. You are not building a new department or new roles; you are building an operating model, a description of new behaviors around how data moves through your organization.

Before you begin building the specific documents that will guide your data governance program you should assess the scope your data governance program will need to take. This is impacted by 4 major factors:

1. Organizational Structure
2. Content of Information
3. Location and Scale of Oversight
4. Data Architecture Methodology

Organizational Structure

No two organizational structures are the same and thinking about the where and how information moves through your organization is a key component to building a DG plan. Below are six common elements of organizational structures and how you might consider them as you build your DG program.

<u>Organizational Structure Component</u>	<u>Considerations for a DG program</u>
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<i>Hierarchy of Authority</i>	- Point(s) of contact for data compliance
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	- Point(s) of contact for data strategy - Integrated or disparate data architecture
<i>Divisional Segmentation</i>	- Alignment of strategic goals - Distribution of DG operational tasks
<i>Job Roles</i>	- Identification of data experts - Discernment of expertise within experts - Capacity to build data literacy among non-data roles
<i>Span of Control</i>	- Distribution of data literacy among management - Relationship of data experts to non-data staff
<i>Level of Formality</i>	- Style of trainings for DG program - Style of trainings for data literacy
<i>Company Culture</i>	- Capacity to build data literacy among non-data roles - Comfort of staff to give feedback or participate in building a DG program

Action Item: Evaluate your organization

Pinpoint at least 2-4 items from the components above and add them to your DG plan. Formally outline how these components fit into the DG vision. Will they need to be tweaked or changed? How will they support the success of your efforts to enhance the organization's use of data?

Content of Information

Your organization's DG program will depend highly on the domain, type and sensitivity of your organization's data.

In this context **Domain** refers to the applied industry your organization belongs in, and therefore the likely categories of information that align. Different industries may have different norms for compliance and structure of data that aligning with may help your organization remain adaptive to growth in the future.

In the context of data, **Type** can describe many components of the type of information individual data points hold. A big category that may be helpful in assessing your organization’s context is whether data is structured or unstructured. Structured data, such as financial spreadsheets, is already separated into individual components for analysis, while unstructured data, such as company emails, contain many pieces of information not yet distinguished into meaningful categories. Considering both of these types of data may help to guide your DG program.

Finally, **Sensitivity** refers to whether or not your company’s data may contain information that could be sensitive to an individual or organization. You will want to consider how to best balance data availability with data security for information falling into a more sensitive category.

Action Item: Clarify the content of information

Consider the content of your data and add relevant notes to your DG plan. How does the content of the information change how the organization interacts with it? Are there any of your core principles relevant here?

Nelson Family Funeral Home

Small Business | 7 Employees

While Nelson Family Funeral Home’s data, consisting of personal details about the deceased person and their loved ones, may interface with some broad regulations aimed at protecting health information, some of their data, such as images and details about the deceased, are sensitive and do not face broad regulation. Nelson Family Funeral Home will have to consider the types of sensitive data they keep in company records when considering a data governance strategy.

Structure of Oversight

It will be important to assess whether decision-making authority for all aspects impacting the DG program are **centralized** or **decentralized**. This will impact not only who is involved in the DG planning but also how you construct the pipeline within the DG program.

Centralization or decentralization are not binary, but rather a spectrum and may differ by area of your organization.

Action Item: Clearly define the structure of oversight

Explicitly outline the structure of oversight for the DG program within your organization. Add this to your DG plan.

Twin Lakes Regional Hospitals

Healthcare Organization | 150 Employees

Twin Lakes Regional Hospitals will have both decentralized and centralized authority for the DG program. While data will be stored and managed primarily by the administrative staff that oversees all Twin Lakes locations, some data management and security will occur at the individual location level.

Data Development / Architecture Methodology

This can best be thought of with the question: **What do we want our data to look like as the organization interacts with it?** It is important at the beginning of this process to take stock in any pre-existing systems. This may include surveying various areas and employees within the organization to understand how data is currently being collected, stored and used. Understanding what current processes and systems exist allow you to leverage work already completed and create alignment where there is none.

This part of your DG program will outline all the tasks that need to occur for your data to be appropriately governed. Essentially, they are the lines of your organization's data "to-do" list to be checked off likely over and over again by various members of your organization. Given these tasks will mostly be repeated processes, it is important that while compiling these tasks you think about what detail might make them successful. This may include:

- ▀ Who will complete the task?
- ▀ How often will it be completed?
- ▀ How will it be documented and measured?
- ▀ What might a standard operating procedure look like?

It is important at this stage to remember that DG is *not* just data management. These tasks should focus on making sure that the day-to-day use of data aligns with the organization's mission, vision, principles, and goals. You are adding appropriate checks at every stage of the data lifecycle to ensure that this alignment can be maintained over time.

The list of tasks itself will be flexible and unique to your organization but we have listed some categories of capabilities you may want to consider:

<u>Capability</u>	<u>Process</u>
Priority Setting	- Defining / identifying data - Ensuring alignment with organizational goals - Delegating tasks - Building partnerships with organizations to learn from
Design	- Building data storage and processing tools - Managing controls / access roles - Monitoring security compliance - Building and maintaining pipelines
Manage	- Monitoring data quality - Ensuring data accessibility - Developing standards for consistent use - Resolving issues
Operate	- Monitoring data Life cycle - Ensuring correct interpretation / translation - Training - Ensuring reporting compliance standards are met

It will also be helpful to engage many types of resources throughout your organization in the creation and assignment of processes. Some of these resources may include:

Information Technology, Human Resources, Legal, Compliance, Risk Management and Project

Action Item: Outline your DG architecture

In your DG plan, add a list of tasks that must be performed for your data to be properly governed. Seek input from the departments and / or employees who are using the data, from leadership, and from other stakeholders as needed. Be clear about the timeframe and accountability for each task. There should always be a separation of duties between those who manage the data and those who govern it.

04 Implementation

Creating a roadmap for your DG program

Align DG With Current Efforts

You should now be ready to kick off the DG process by evaluating which projects and programs the DG effort will oversee. You will consider the organization's current projects and choose an activity where DG can assist the project in achieving its goals, but not appear to be interfering. The goal is to become embedded in the project, not to simply make observations or suggestions. Your goal is to demonstrate that DG is not a threat and that you're there to help, not to make things harder.

The steps in this process include:

1. **Make a list of projects**

Make a list of the organization's current projects. Include *all* projects, even if they don't seem obviously data intensive.

2. **Consider where DG can help**

Separate the list into two sections: projects where DG can help, and projects where DG will not be able to help.

3. **Create a "save for later" list**

Create a third section for projects that DG can help but where that help will be complex or otherwise difficult. This will be your "save for later" list. You can tackle these projects once the DG program has some legs. If there are any projects that are politically charged within the organization, move them to this list.

4. **Choose your first project**

Evaluate your remaining projects and rank them by the order in which you want to tackle them. Your goal is to implement the DG program in increments. You want to implement it in small pieces. You want to create visibility without ruffling feathers. As

you generate value and create good impressions, you can begin to expand the DG program to the other projects on your list.

It may be tempting to start with the biggest, most high-profile project you can find, or the project that is the messiest and most in need of DG. Try to resist this temptation. You want to create trust and goodwill before you try to tackle the organization's most difficult or politically charged data problems.

Action Item: Pick your project

Work through the steps outlined above and select the project with which you want to start the DG implementation.

Set Yourself Up for Success

Before you jump into your DG efforts, it is vital to set the right foundation for your success. There may be resistance at first, or there may be a lack of understanding around why DG is important. It is your job to consider potential complications and prepare for them. You want to create the right scaffolding to support the DG program until it can stand on its own.

Enlist a sponsor

The right sponsor can be the biggest success factor in your initial DG effort. This person should have influence and the ability to make things happen in the organization. Unfortunately, in most organizations IT does not have the credibility to sponsor something like DG. Go after a leader in the organization and keep pushing until you get the right one.

Foster data literacy

What would data literacy look like *in action* in your organization? Do employees understand the concepts they are being asked to adopt? If you are providing training on specific tools and procedures, are there ways you can incorporate “why” of DG? You need to articulate how understanding DG will become a “business as usual” activity for the organization.

The steps for achieving data literacy include:

1. Measure if there is a basic understanding of DG within your organization.
2. Take the necessary steps to achieve understanding of what DG is and how it adds value.
3. Describe the everyday, specific workflow for interacting with DG. For every DG capability or tool, you should specify how each level of employee will interact with that capability or tool.
4. Look for and assist your stakeholders in creating behaviors around DG that are instinctive and automatic.

You should be specific about what is changing so that the people impacted know exactly what to start, what to stop, and what to continue to do.

Move from the general to the specific. You have spent time defining the big-picture vision of your DG plan. Every stakeholder should be aware of this vision! From there, you can narrow down the training and tailor it to the specific departments or employees and the specific skills and knowledge they will need.

Action Item: Enlist a sponsor

Identify 1 sponsor who has political capital within the organization. Consider how you can help educate them on the importance and benefits of DG, then reach out!

Action Item: Evaluate your organization's data literacy

How can you measure the data literacy in your organization? Informal interviews or surveys may be helpful here. Take steps to measure data literacy, and then make a game plan with specific steps for creating greater data literacy.

Define Your Success Metrics

You will need to prove the effectiveness and value of your DG efforts. This requires concrete, specific data that measures whether the program is achieving its objectives and whether training is effective.

Some success metrics you may want to consider

<u>Category</u>	<u>Metric</u>
Risk	- Cost per downtime event - Loss of customer confidence - Liquidity - Operational costs
People	- Number of data owners identified - DG adoption rate by department (survey) - Productivity increase due to issue resolution
Process	- Number of projects actively integrating DG - Number of issues escalated to DG evaluation - Increased efficiency of projects or lowered project costs - Trainings that happened and number of attendees
Technology	- Number of data sources consolidated - Number of spreadsheets used - Data integrity across applications - Improved reporting efficiency and accuracy

Less metrics will likely be most effective. Focus on the story you want to tell about your DG program and which metrics will best help you tell that story.

Action Item: Identify success metrics

Identify 1-3 metrics to define the success of your DG plan. Add these to your plan along with specific timeframes and processes for obtaining these metrics.

Consider New Capabilities & Tools

You have already considered your existing capabilities and tools, and we cautioned against rushing out to buy expensive new tools or consultants to “do DG” for you. By this point, you should have a better understanding of what DG will look like in your organization, and a sense of the gap between where you are and where you want to be. If you still feel that you need additional tools, now would be the time to build them into your DG roadmap.

However, we sincerely hope you have discovered that you already have everything you need to be successful at DG. There is no shortage of companies willing to sell you expensive DG tools, especially with the recent interest in artificial intelligence, but DG doesn’t have to be complicated. It’s simply a way to think through what responsible use of data means for your organization, and to formalize that vision into a sustainable culture of data use in your day-to-day work.

05 Templates

To get you started

Data Identification Checklist

Use this checklist with your organization's Data Governance team to identify which types of data the organization currently manages. For more guidance on using this checklist, see [Assess](#) in Section 1: Engagement.

Restricted Data: *Highest sensitivity. Unauthorized access could cause severe harm to individuals or to the organization.*

- ☐ Social Security Numbers
- ☐ Credit card information
- ☐ Bank account details
- ☐ Login credentials and passwords
- ☐ Personal health information
- ☐ Biometric data
- ☐ Trade secrets and proprietary algorithms
- ☐ Source code for proprietary algorithms
- ☐ Disability accommodation records
- ☐ Attorney-client privileged communications
- ☐ Other: _____

Confidential Data: *Sensitive business information. Unauthorized access could harm the organization or stakeholders.*

- ☐ Employee personnel files
- ☐ Salary and compensation data
- ☐ Performance reviews
- ☐ Strategic business plans
- ☐ Contract negotiations
- ☐ Customer contact lists
- ☐ Vendor agreements
- ☐ Other: _____

Internal Data: *Internal business information. Should not be public but limited harm if disclosed.*

- ☐ Internal policies and procedures
- ☐ Employee directory
- ☐ Office locations and hours
- ☐ Internal newsletters
- ☐ Meeting minutes (non-sensitive)
- ☐ Training materials
- ☐ Project status updates
- ☐ Organizational charts
- ☐ Other: _____

Public Data: *Information intended for public consumption. No restrictions on disclosure.*

- ☐ Marketing materials
- ☐ Press releases
- ☐ Published annual reports
- ☐ Website content
- ☐ Social media posts
- ☐ Product catalogs
- ☐ Job postings
- ☐ Public event information
- ☐ Other: _____

Identify Your Organization's Top Priorities

Use this space to identify your organization's top priorities. For more guidance on writing your goals, please see [Vision & Plan](#) in Section 2: Strategy.

Operational Excellence

- ☐ Improving efficiency or reducing costs
- ☐ Streamlining workflows and eliminating bottlenecks
- ☐ Shortening delivery times or turnaround times
- ☐ Reducing waste or environmental impact
- ☐ Other: _____

Growth & Revenue

- ☐ Growing revenue
- ☐ Launching new products or services
- ☐ Entering new markets or geographic areas
- ☐ Other: _____

Customer/Client Focus

- ☐ Increasing customer loyalty
- ☐ Reducing customer complaints or service issues
- ☐ Building long-term relationships with key clients
- ☐ Other: _____

Risk & Compliance

- ☐ Ensuring compliance with regulations
- ☐ Reducing legal or regulatory risks
- ☐ Improving data security and privacy protections
- ☐ Meeting industry certification or accreditation standards
- ☐ Other: _____

People & Culture

- ☐ Attracting and retaining top talent
- ☐ Improving employee satisfaction and engagement
- ☐ Reducing employee turnover
- ☐ Promoting diversity, equity, and inclusion
- ☐ Other: _____

Quality & Performance

- ☐ Improving product or service quality
- ☐ Reducing defect rates or service failures
- ☐ Improving consistency across locations or teams
- ☐ Other: _____

Community & Stakeholder Relations

- ☐ Improving transparency and accountability to stakeholders
- ☐ Demonstrating social responsibility and impact
- ☐ Building trust with key constituencies
- ☐ Addressing community needs or concerns
- ☐ Other: _____

Financial Health

- ☐ Improving profitability or margins
- ☐ Reducing debt or improving financial stability
- ☐ Attracting investment or funding
- ☐ Improving financial reporting and visibility
- ☐ Other: _____

Map Data Opportunities to Organizational Goals

Once you have identified your organization’s top priorities, connect your goals to data opportunities. For examples, see [Vision & Plan](#) in Section 2: Strategy.

Goal	How Data Could Help	Specific Data Needed
1.		
2.		
3.		

Inventory Your Existing Data Capabilities

Create a list of current capabilities in your organization. Consider dividing these into three categories: technical capabilities, people capabilities, process capabilities, and capability gaps. For examples, see [Existing Capabilities & Tools](#) in Section 2: Strategy.

Technical Capabilities:

- What databases or data systems do you currently use?
- Do you have tools for analyzing data (Excel, reporting software, dashboards)?
- Can employees easily access the data they need?
- Is data backed up regularly?

People Capabilities:

- Who in your organization is comfortable working with data?
- Who creates reports or analyzes trends?
- Who maintains databases or systems?
- Who answers questions about data quality or definitions?

Process Capabilities:

- How do you currently ensure data accuracy?
- How do you decide who can access sensitive information?
- How do you handle data requests from different departments?
- How do you archive or delete old data?

Common capability gaps:

- **Access issues:** For example, when customer service staff cannot access customer data, forcing customers to repeat information about their orders.
- **Analysis issues:** For example, when customer feedback data is collected, but is never analyzed to find trends over time.
- **Integration issues:** For example, when the sales and operations systems do not talk to each other.
- **Security issues:** For example, when sensitive employee data is stored in shared folders that anyone can access.

Data Governance Principle Template

Use this template to write your DG principles. For examples, see [Principles](#) in Section 2: Strategy.

Principle Name: [Which GAIP principle]

Our Statement: [Rewrite the principle in your own words, specific to your organization]

Why This Matters for Us: [Explain why you chose this principle—what problem does it solve or what value does it create?]

What This Means in Practice: [Give two to three concrete examples of decisions or actions guided by this principle]

Ethical Considerations: [How does this principle relate to fairness, transparency, dignity, or stakeholder wellbeing?]

Potential Challenges: [Acknowledge where this principle might be difficult to uphold]

Data Ethics Template

Use this template to write your data ethics guidelines. For examples, see [Ethics](#) in Section 2: Strategy.

Focus Area: [Name the goal or capability you are developing]

Stakeholders Affected: [Who will be impacted by how you collect, use, or share this data? Consider: customers/clients, employees, vulnerable populations, communities, partners]

Privacy Considerations:

- What personal or sensitive information is involved?
- Do stakeholders know this data is being collected?
- Have they consented in a meaningful way (not just clicking "I agree")?
- How long will you retain this data? Why?

Fairness Considerations:

- Could data collection or analysis disadvantage certain groups?
- Are you collecting data from/about people who cannot easily opt out?
- Could patterns in your data reflect historical biases rather than current reality?
- Who benefits from this data use? Who bears the risks?

Transparency Considerations:

- Can you clearly explain to a non-technical person why you're collecting this data?
- If someone asked how you use their data, could you tell them?
- Would you be comfortable if your data practices were publicly reported?
- Is there someone accountable for data decisions in this area?

Dignity Considerations:

- Are you treating people as partners in your data practices, or as sources of data to be extracted?
- Are you making decisions about people without their input?

Harm Prevention:

- What's the worst thing that could happen if this data was breached or misused?
- Could your analysis lead to discrimination, even unintentionally?
- What safeguards exist to prevent misuse?